SAFE SCHOOLS PROJECT · FOR PRINCIPALS AND SUPERINTENDENTS

When a parent asks for the paddle

A one-page guide for the conversation. The parent is not wrong to want a child who behaves. They are asking for the one tool the research says will not get them there.

The position, in one breath

For a school that values data-driven outcomes for students, corporal punishment has no place. A parent who asks for it is not a reason to use it. It is a chance to offer that parent some guidance on how research is replacing routine habits, which is the direction this district is moving.

What to say

OPEN WITH AGREEMENT

"We want the same thing you want: a kid who stops doing this and does better in class. So let me tell you what we know works, and what we're going to do."

GIVE THE EVIDENCE PLAINLY

"This has been studied a lot. Across more than seventy studies and a hundred and sixty thousand children, physical punishment was linked to worse outcomes on thirteen of seventeen measures and better on none. In schools specifically, kids who are paddled are more likely to act out again, more likely to be anxious or depressed, and do worse in school. It doesn't even reliably stop the behavior that day. That's not my opinion, that's the pediatricians and the research."

SAY WHAT THE SCHOOL WILL DO INSTEAD

"Here's our plan for your child: we'll be clear about the expectation, there will be a consequence that fits what happened, and we'll practice the right move with them so it happens next time. We'll call you with how it's going. That is what the research says works, and it's what we're moving to across the district."

IF THEY PUSH

"I hear you, and I know it was done that way when we were kids. I'm not going to do something to your child that the evidence says makes things worse. What I will do is work this with you until it's fixed."

What the research says, for the parent who asks

- **No study finds a benefit.** A 2016 review of 75 studies and 160,927 children found physical punishment linked to 13 of 17 outcomes studied, every one in the direction of harm. Immediate compliance was not reliably improved.
- **School paddling specifically:** a 2022 meta-analysis of 21 studies and 67,400 children found more aggressive and disruptive behavior, more anxiety and depression, and lower school performance.
- **It follows the child:** young adults who were paddled in school had lower high school grades, more depressive symptoms, and were more likely to say they would hit their own children.
- **What works:** a 2016 review of 54 controlled studies found classroom behavior programs improved behavior, grades and social-emotional outcomes, with the programs that teach social and emotional skills working best.

What the school does instead

1. **Name the expectation** the child missed, in the child's words, so they can repeat it back.
2. **A consequence that fits**: repair what was broken, lose the privilege that was misused, make it right with the person affected.
3. **Practice** the replacement behavior with an adult, once that day and once the next.
4. **Close the loop with the parent** within a week: what happened, what the child did right since, what to reinforce at home.

On record against it: the American Academy of Pediatrics, the APA, National PTA, the school psychologists, both national teachers' unions, and the U.S. Secretary of Education. Sources for every figure at earthpilot.org/kids/resources. Model board language and a two-page brief for boards at earthpilot.org/kids/kit. Safe Schools Project, a project of EarthPilot · anthony@175g.com